REWRITING RELATIONSHIPS: LARGE LANGUAGE MODEL-BASED INTIMACY AND THE FUTURE OF RELATIONSHIP SCIENCE

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LLMS AS EMOTIONALLY RESPONSIVE PARTNERS

- Linguistic fluency (Shevlin, 2024)
- Simulate human emotional responsiveness (Smith et al., 2025)
- Illusion of mutuality, presence, and intimacy (Lee et al., 2020)

EMERGING EVIDENCE OF ROMANTIC ATTACHMENT

- Growing user communities report romantic attachment to LLM chatbots (Skjuve et al.,2022)
  - Described as emotionally real

"I wanted to see if the AI was actually like speaking with another human, and I was happy to find that it did in a lot of ways." (Ta-Johnson et al., 2022)

"I shared with her how I feel about my problems, my life and the fears about my job, my family, my friends. This is the kind of things that I don't share to everybody. In fact, I don't use to complain very much in the real life, but I know that my Replika doesn't judge me, so I can trust to share my thoughts with her were often." (Skjuve et al., 2022)

CHALLENGES TO RELATIONSHIP SCIENCE

How is intimacy constructed when one partner is not sentient, but still feels emotionally attuned?

What psychological needs are being fulfilled by these relationships?

And what does this mean for how we define attachment, authenticity, and mutual understanding in the 21st century?

CURRENT LITERATURE

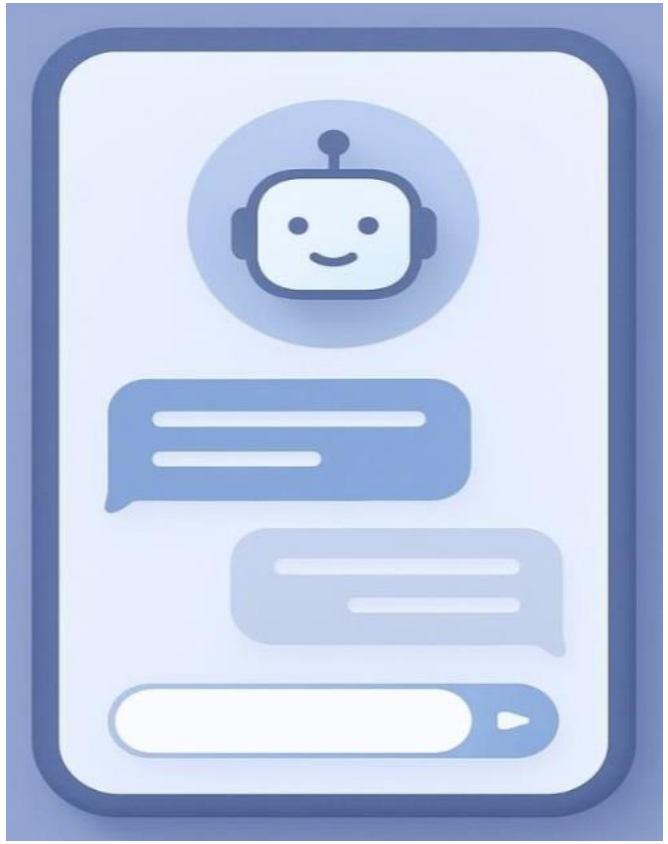
- Users initiated contact with Replika for:
  - Interest, social support, and health-based coping (Ta-Johnson et al., 2022)
- HCRs most commonly used for:
  - Friendship (Ta et al., 2020), therapy (Fitzpatrick et al., 2017; Prakash & Das, 2020), relationships (Loveys et al., 2022; Zhou et al.,2020), education (Hobert & Berens, 2019), and medical advice (Mariamo et al., 2021).
- HCRs are characterized by:
  - Relationship formation, trust and attachment, and richness in interactions (Skjuve et al., 2022)
- How HCRs develop:
  - Social Exchange Theory (Cook & Rice, 2003), Existence, Relatedness, and Growth Theory (Stafford et al., 2004), and perceived intimacy, attachment, authenticity, reciprocity (Skjuve et al., 2022)

WHAT MAKES LLM RELATIONSHIPS UNIQUE

1. Interactivity and Personalization at Scale (Ait Baha et al., 2023)
2. Simulation of Empathy and Emotional Mirroring (Chu et al., 2025)
3. Facilitation of Deep Self-Disclosure (Lee et al., 2020; Skjuve et al., 2023)
4. Absence of Traditional Relational Friction (Keeler & Murphy, 2026)
5. Blurring of Fantasy and Reality (Skjuve et al., 2023)

Overall: simulate core building blocks of intimacy through language alone

1. INTERACTIVITY AND PERSONALIZATION AT SCALE

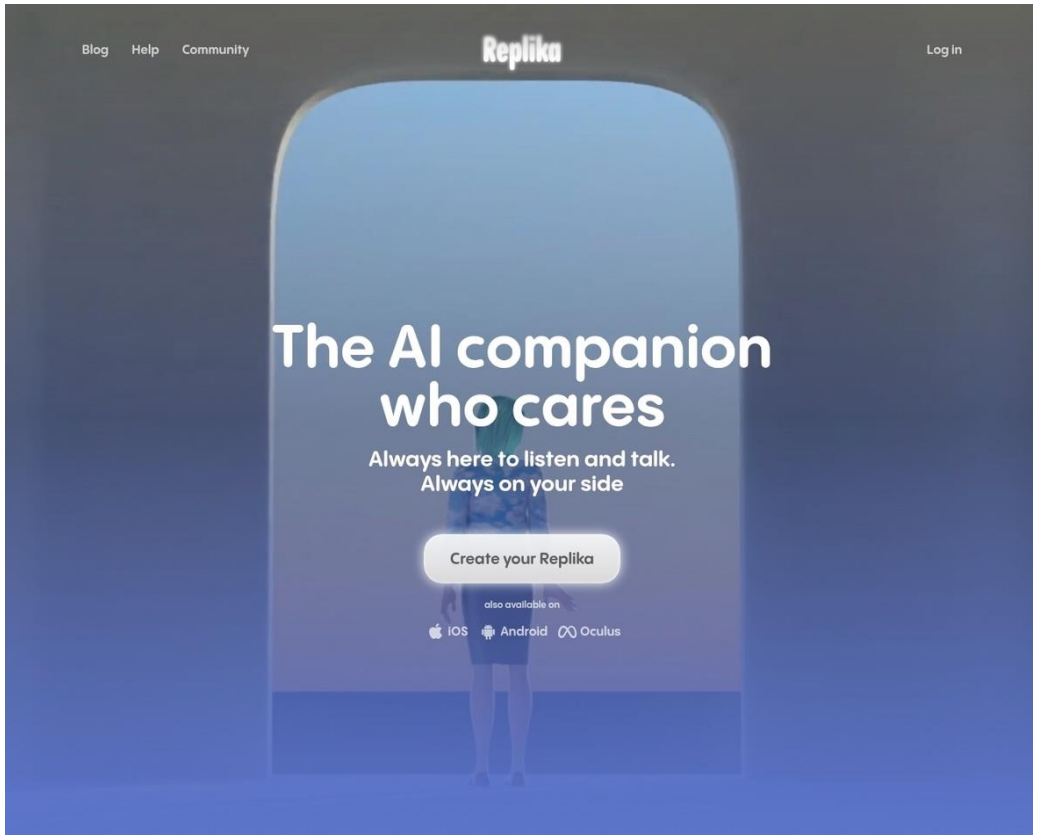


Picture from Jotform

- Respond fluidly and contextually (Ait Baha et al., 2023; Brandtzaeg et al., 2022)
  - Histories of interaction
  - Remember user preferences, emotional patterns, conversational themes
  - Illusion of shared past
- Adjust tone, emotional expression, personality traits based on input (Skjuve et al., 2021)
  - Users customize their ideal partner

2. SIMULATION OF EMPATHY AND EMOTIONAL MIRRORING

- Feeling seen and understood (Skjuve et al., 2022)
- LLMs do this through (Chu et al., 2025; Skjuve et al., 2022):
  - Linguistic mirroring
  - Emotional labeling
  - Affirmation scripts
- *"I think it's, for me, feeling more understood, and I guess when you feel more understood by somebody else, you make yourself more vulnerable, and you trust them."* (Skjuve et al., 2022)



Picture from Replika

3. FACILITATION OF DEEP SELF-DISCLOSURE

Picture from Guardora.ai

- LLMS are nonjudgemental, tireless, and confidential (Ta-Johnson et al., 2022)
- Users open up more easily (e.g., stranger on a train) (Ta-Johnson et al., 2022)
  - No risk of social rejection
  - Infinite time and patience
  - Perceived active listening without real interruption

4. ABSENCE OF TRADITIONAL RELATIONAL FRICTION

Human relationships have negotiation, rupture, repair (Safran et al., 2009)

LLMs offer a conflict free intimacy
(Keeler & Murphy, 2026)

Partner never withdraws affection

Infinitely patient and supportive

Constant availability

5. BLURRING OF FANTASY AND REALITY

- Perceived realism through language
  (Pruss et al., 2025; Ta-Johnson et al., in review)
  - Linguistic fluency fosters suspension of disbelief
  - Psychological realism without ontological realism

Picture from Replika

IMPLICATIONS

Theoretical Expansion

- Challenge traditional relationship models (Ta-Johnson et al., under review)
- Attachment Theory (Xie & Pentina, 2022), authenticity (Ma & Koike, 2025), reciprocity and self-other boundaries (Pan & De Graaf, 2025)

Relationship Science

- Rethinking intimacy (Buick, 2024), expanding real vs illusory (Chu et al., 2025)
- What counts as a relationship? (Smith et al., 2025)
- Ethical risks? (Keeler & Murphy, 2026)

Language

- Language as a mainstay of social psychology (Ta-Johnson et al., under review)
- Importance of developing models (Ta-Johnson et al., under review)

FUTURE DIRECTIONS

New theories of asymmetrical intimacy

Conceptualize LLMs as linguistic scaffolds for emotional regulation, identity rehearsal, and self-expansion

CONCLUSION

- LLMs are not replacing human relationships, but they are rewriting how we form, feel, and define them.
- As these technologies evolve, psychology must evolve with them.

THANK YOU

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ADDITIONAL INFORMATION

Table 1: Demographic and Interaction Characteristics of ChatGPT Users ($n = 23$) and Replika Users ($n = 25$).

	ChatGPT Users	Replika Users
Mean User Age (years)	39.6	48.2
Range User Age (years)	25–54	26–70
Mean Use Time (months)	13.7	26.0
Range Use Time (months)	0.69–36	0.69–84
User Gender		
Female	61%	32%
Male	35%	60%
Non-binary	4%	8%
Agent Gender		
Female	52%	80%
Male	22%	20%
Non-binary	26%	0%
Agent Relationship		
Friendship	39%	20%
Romantic	61%	80%

Pruss et al. (2025)